

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Mayor seeks \$90M to end suits tied to corrupt cop

Agreement would settle wrongful conviction cases involving Watts

By Jake Sheridan and Jason Meisner
Chicago Tribune

Mayor Brandon Johnson is proposing a historic \$90 million taxpayer-funded “global settlement” to resolve almost 200 lawsuits tied to a single disgraced Chicago police sergeant in what’s shaping up to be one of the costliest scandals in the department’s history.

The first-of-its-kind deal, uncovered by the Tribune in federal court records, would settle all outstanding wrongful conviction cases involving Sgt. Ronald Watts, according to Corporation Counsel Mary Richardson-Lowry.

The top Johnson attorney said the massive payout is “the responsible thing to do,” arguing it could save the city as much as \$400 million compared to the cost of settling the cases individually or taking them to court.

“We spent a lot of years kicking cans down the road,” Richardson-Lowry said. “We cannot carry that burden further. We have to solve for these cases. ... We have to close that chapter.”

But it remains to be seen whether Johnson, who has struggled to get restive aldermen to go along with several relatively modest police misconduct settlements in the past few years, can convince them to sign off on the massive Watts agreement.

The mountain of Watts cases has loomed over City Hall for years, an avalanche of staggeringly costly settlements or verdicts bearing down on the cash-strapped city. The former sergeant, who for years was in charge of a tactical crew that patrolled the Ida B. Wells public housing complex on the South Side, is alleged by 180 plaintiffs in 176 pending federal court cases to have made phony drug arrests that landed many in prison.

More than 180 people had their convictions overturned in recent years, followed by a flood of certificates of innocence and lawsuits alleging Watts framed them while acting on the city’s behalf.

Johnson’s administration believes the dark facts of the cases give Chicago attorneys little chance to win in court.

“The liability issues for the city are clear,” Richardson-Lowry said in an exclusive interview. “We have two officers that were investigated by the FBI, pled guilty, served time, lost their pension. The probability of a favorable outcome here is de minimis at best.”

After the settlement proposal was announced, attorneys Scott Rauscher and Joshua Tepfer, who together represented about 130 Watts accusers, told the Tribune that reaching a deal took innovation and “reasonableness” from both sides.

“The city should get credit for taking a hard look at the facts and

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People pray at a makeshift memorial for Charlie Kirk, who was fatally shot on Wednesday, outside the Turning Point USA headquarters in Scottsdale, Ariz., on Thursday. **ADRIANA ZEHBRAUSKAS/THE NEW YORK TIMES**

Officials seek public’s help in Kirk’s killing

FBI releases photos of person of interest, posts \$100,000 reward; rifle found

By Eric Tucker, Alanna Durkin Richer and Jesse Bedayn
Associated Press

OREM, Utah — The FBI released two photos of a person of interest in the assassination of Charlie Kirk, a close ally of President Donald Trump who played an influential role in rallying young Republican voters. The shooter, who fired a single shot from a distant roof, remained at large and unidentified on Thursday more than 24 hours into the investigation.

The release of photos of a person in a hat, sunglasses and a

long-sleeved black shirt, as well as a \$100,000 reward issued by the FBI for information leading to an arrest, reflected law enforcement’s urgent appeal for public help in locating the shooter, who vanished after jumping off the roof and fleeing through a wooded area near the Utah university where Kirk was killed in a targeted attack.

Investigators were sifting through potential clues, including a palm print and a shoe impression found near the scene, as well as a Mauser .30-caliber bolt-action rifle hidden in a towel in a wooded area near the university campus along what they

suspect to be the path the shooter took while fleeing. Besides the spent cartridge recovered in the chamber, three other rounds were loaded in the magazine, according to information circulated among law enforcement and described to The Associated Press. The weapon and ammunition are being forensically analyzed by law enforcement at a federal lab for clues that could help identify the shooter or the motive.

At a news conference Thursday, authorities said that the suspect’s college-age appearance

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A photo shows a person of interest sought by the FBI in connection with the shooting death of Charlie Kirk. **FBI**

Friends recall Kirk as man who ‘inspired millions’

Conservative activist started Turning Point USA in the suburbs

By Rebecca Johnson, Kate Perez, Tess Kenny, Dan Petrella and Kate Armanini
Chicago Tribune

The first time businessman Gary Rabine met Charlie Kirk, the then-18-year-old conservative activist showed up for a fundraiser at a far northwest suburban golf club to network and expand what seemed at the time to Rabine like a “little cause.”

Rabine, who had founded a Schaumburg-based paving company and later went on to run an unsuccessful Republican primary campaign for governor in 2022, told the Tribune he had reservations but agreed to sit down for a quick chat with Kirk about four hours later, which was well past midnight.

“He explained to me and my late wife about his goals and his dreams,” Rabine said. “He said, ‘I want to build an organization that educates kids everywhere, on college campuses all over America, on why God is great and why America is great.’ He really

hooked me on that.”

That “little cause,” of course, was Turning Point USA, Kirk’s organization that grew to national prominence with the help of financial backers like Rabine. On Wednesday, Kirk, the 31-year-old conservative firebrand and close ally of President Donald Trump, who grew up in the Chicago suburbs, was shot and killed at a Utah college in what the state’s governor called a political assassination. A bipartisan outcry against political violence followed.

Law enforcement officials said Thursday that the killer,

who “appears to be of college age,” jumped off a roof and fled after firing the fatal shot. While authorities continued their search for the shooter, those who knew Kirk personally in the Chicago area spent the day reflecting on his life. His local mourners included college students influenced by his brand of brazen Christian conservatism and incendiary comments, which often incorporated racist, misogynistic and homophobic language.

“Charlie inspired millions of

Turn to Kirk, Page 4

Pollen season is lasting longer, worsening allergies



Dr. Rachna Shah opens a spore trap and removes a glass slide containing pollen on the rooftop of her office in Melrose Park on Thursday. She collects pollen daily from March to October. **STACEY WESCOTT/TRIBUNE**

Shorter winters mean longer growing season, affecting insects too

By Adriana Pérez
Chicago Tribune

Fall is in the air. Chicago evenings have a crisp breeze. But something has been bugging Annie Andrews.

Specifically, bees and wasps and a whole lot of sneezing.

“It’s gotten to a point, like, I couldn’t stop sneezing during a shift,” said the 28-year-old restaurant server. Earlier this week, she thought, “I need to take an allergy pill again.” When she waits tables outside, the insects swarm patrons, who desperately ask her to be moved elsewhere,

anywhere the bees and the wasps aren’t.

Chicagoans from all over can likely relate. Pollen has concentrated in the city over the past three weeks, mostly from ragweed. Wednesday counts were the highest recorded so far this year — the last time the area had so much ragweed was in 2018, according to Loyola Medicine.

Allergy season is getting worse, climate science nonprofit Climate Central reports. And shorter winters are contributing to more days with high pollen counts and buzzing insects that can derail residents’ hopes for peaceful patio dining.

A warmer, earlier spring and a

Turn to Pollen, Page 5

INSIDE



CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

QB hindsight

Bears quarterback Caleb Williams faced some notable struggles during Monday’s loss to the Vikings. A look at what worked and what didn’t. **Chicago Sports**

Changes at court

Judge Charles Beach’s election as chief judge ushers in a new era for the Cook County court system, which had been led by Judge Tim Evans for 24 years. **Page 9**

